submerged, the Project 629s and Project 658s needed to surface to prepare their liquid-fuelled missiles for launch.

The Soviet plan also included four diesel-electric powered Project 641 submarines (NATO designation Foxtrot). These belonged to the Northern Fleet based in the Kola Peninsula. Their experiences are closely studied later – many believe they were involved in the most dangerous moments of the Cuban missile crisis. There are also indications that some cruise missile submarines operated in the North Atlantic during the crisis, equipped with nuclear-armed missiles.[75] Cuban ports would also host a Soviet surface fleet, comprising two cruisers, four destroyers, and twelve Komar missile-carrying patrol boats. All told, the naval contingent comprised 5,640 men.

Interestingly, when, in September 1962, the CIA concluded it was improbable that Khrushchev would deploy nuclear missiles in Cuba, they nevertheless acknowledged that Moscow 'could derive considerable military advantage'from medium and intermediate range ballistic missiles in Cuba or from a submarine base; 'As between these two, the establishment of a submarine base would be the more likely.'[76] Would a purely submarine-based missile force have better served Soviet purposes? The answer depends in part on what exactly those purposes were. When the Kennedy administration considered withdrawal of the Jupiter missiles from Turkey, deploying Polaris submarines to replace them helped assuage Turkish concerns about Washington's commitment to Turkish security. And in 1963 when the Jupiters were withdrawn from Italy and Turkey, NATO deployed several Polaris submarines in the Eastern Mediterranean. Project 629 boats based at Mariel would have posed a different challenge than MRBMs and IRBMs. Once they could operate within missile range of US targets, including Washington, they would have posed a credible threat to the United States. Whether they would have been politically more visible or militarily less vulnerable are open to question.

Khrushchev believed that once the MRBMs and IRBMs were operational, they would deter a US attack on Cuba. Substantial conventional forces were also needed to protect the missile sites and support the Cuban army. Further to the weapons supplied previously to the Cubans, Operation Anadyr included four motorised regiments, two tank